

Stacking the Noun Phrase: A Determiner Workshop

This 60-minute activity focuses on practising pre-determiners, central determiners, and post-determiners (Topic 2) and especially on understanding their correct ordering within the noun phrase. I wanted the activity to feel less like a traditional grammar exercise and more like a collaborative puzzle-solving task, because determiner order can easily become too abstract or mechanical when explained only theoretically.

Students work in randomly assigned trios at vertical whiteboards. Each group receives a set of cards containing isolated determiners from all three subclasses (e.g., *all*, *both*, *half*; *the*, *my*, *this*; *many*, *few*, *three*, *several*) together with a list of head nouns. Their task is to create the longest grammatically acceptable noun phrase possible while identifying and marking the function of each slot within the phrase. An important part of the activity is not only producing the phrase itself, but also justifying why the order works grammatically.

After approximately fifteen minutes, groups rotate in a gallery walk and analyse another group's board. They identify ordering violations or problematic combinations - for example *the my book* or *three every days* - and leave comments or corrections on sticky notes. I think this stage is especially useful because students begin noticing patterns and restrictions more actively when evaluating someone else's work rather than only their own.

The activity ends with a short plenary discussion where the class reviews the most difficult or disputed examples together. In my opinion, this final stage helps reinforce the slot-based structure of the English noun phrase while also encouraging discussion and collaborative reasoning rather than simple memorization.